

AUDITION PACKET · WITH SIDES

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

by Luigi Pirandello · translated by Edward Storer

A Village Players production

Lausanne, Switzerland

ABOUT THE PRODUCTION

The Village Players are casting Pirandello's metatheatrical comedy for a bold minimalist staging in Lausanne. Eight live performers carry the production. The Boy and the Child are not cast — they are objects on the stage (a coat-and-chair, a wrapped bundle). The rear wall lights up three times briefly; otherwise the stage is bare.

Each act has a single defining visual element: a circle of chairs in Act One; a two-level set in Act Two; a single short fountain basin alone on stage in Act Three. The English of this version is contemporary. The first quarter of an hour is committed comedy. The last quarter of an hour is not.

WHAT THIS PACKET CONTAINS

For each of the eight casting tracks you will find **two pages**: first, a description of the role with stats, playing direction, and a short cold-read line; then, on the following page, a set of **audition sides** — actual lines from the production, ready to prepare. Choose one or more sides per role. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

AUDITIONS

WHERE	Lausanne — venue to be confirmed
WHEN	By appointment
WHAT TO PREPARE	One sides selection from the role you are auditioning for, plus an optional one-minute monologue of your choice.
SELF-TAPES	Accepted for the first round.

HOW TO APPLY

Send headshot, CV, and a brief note on which role you wish to audition for, to:
casting [at] villageplayers [dot] ch. Please indicate any access requirements.

The Father

the brain of the family

161 speeches · 4,828 words across the production

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

COLD-READ LINE

“Each one of us has within him a whole world of things, and to every one of us our own world.”

Act Three — the philosophical voice

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

The Father

SIDE 1 *Act One — the consciousness speech*

The Father. For the drama lies all in this — in the conscience that I have, that each one of us has. We believe this conscience to be a single thing; but it is many-sided. So we have the illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. We perceive this when, tragically perhaps, in something we do, we are caught up, suspended on a kind of hook. Then we see that all of us was not in that act, and that it would be an atrocious injustice to judge us by that action alone, as if all our existence were summed up in that one deed. Now do you understand the perfidy of this girl? She surprised me in a place where she ought not to have known me — and now seeks to attach to me a reality I could never have supposed I would have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life.

SIDE 2 *Act One — describing how the drama ends*

The Father. He disappears soon, you know. And the baby too. She is the first to vanish from the scene. The drama consists finally in this: when that mother re-enters my house, her family — born outside of it and superimposed on the original — ends with the death of the little girl, the tragedy of the boy, and the flight of the elder daughter. It cannot go on, because it is foreign to its surroundings. So we three remain — I, the mother, that son — and find ourselves strange to one another. We live in an atmosphere of mortal desolation, which is the revenge, as he [*Indicating the Son.*] scornfully said, of the Demon of Experiment that unfortunately hides in me. When faith is lacking, it becomes impossible to create certain states of happiness.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

The Mother

silence that finally screams

36 speeches · 544 words across the production

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil; beneath it, when she lifts it, a face the colour of wax. Crushed and terrified, as if pressed down by a weight too great to name. Silent for most of Act One — then, in Act Two, her presence becomes a sound, the only true unmediated cry in the play. Stillness is her language. Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that.

COLD-READ LINE

“It's taking place now. It happens all the time.”

Act Two — the only true unmediated cry

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

The Mother

SIDE 1 *Act Two — the central cry*

The Mother. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she [*Indicating the Step-Daughter.*] has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

SIDE 2 *Act One — defending her past*

The Mother. [*vigorously*]. He forced me to it, and I call God to witness it. [*To the Manager.*] Ask him [*Indicates Husband.*] if it isn't true. Let him speak. You [*To Daughter.*] are not in a position to know anything about it.

SIDE 3 *Act Two — under accusation*

The Mother. And isn't my punishment the worst of all? [*Then seeing from the Son's manner that he will not bother himself about her.*] My God! Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to support all this torment? Must you make others see it too?

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

The Step-Daughter

the one who refuses to let it be made beautiful

115 speeches · 3,119 words across the production

She is the moral centre of the play. Not the Father with his philosophy, not the Manager with his stagecraft — her. Her anger is precise: she is in a room of theatre people who would like to turn what happened to her into *a scene, a moment, a confession* — anything but what it is. She refuses. Every line of hers is some version of *stop making this beautiful. Stop making this clever. Stop making this safe. This happened. Look at it.* She is dressed in elegant mourning and she knows how to use a room; the seduction the old text gestures at is not flirtation but exposure — a weapon turned outward because everything else has been taken from her. Play her sharp, in control, never apologetic, never coquettish. The wit is real but the wit is rage. Her tenderness for the Child — for the bundle — must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy reads as the same wound, pointed the other way. She has a single projected moment in Act Two — the only audible projection in the production — where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child, then violent with the Boy when she finds the revolver in his pocket. Below the screen, her live body stands silent, listening to her own recorded voice. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him, and she will not be staged into doing so.

COLD-READ LINE

“And I came as mistress of the house.”

Act Two — the shop scene

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

The Step-Daughter

SIDE 1 *Act Two opening — to the bundle*

The Step-Daughter. *[bends over the Child and takes her face between her hands].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to a question of the Child.]* What is the stage? It's a place, baby, where people play at being serious — and we've got to act a comedy now, dead serious. You're in it too. A garden — a fountain — look — just suppose, kiddie, it's here, right in the middle. It's all pretence, my pet. All make-believe here. Better to imagine it, because if they fix it up for you, it'll only be painted cardboard — for the rockery, the water, the plants. Ah, but I think a baby like this would sooner have a make-believe fountain than a real one. What a joke it'll be for the others! But for you, alas, not such a joke. You who are real, baby dear, and really play by a real fountain, big and green and beautiful, with bamboos around and a whole lot of little ducks swimming. — *[In the video, the Step-Daughter seizes the Boy by the arm.]* What have you got there? *[In the video, she catches the glint of a revolver in his pocket.]* Ah! Where did you get this? Idiot! If I'd been in your place, instead of killing myself I'd have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

SIDE 2 *Act Three — at the fountain*

The Step-Daughter. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep with her — I, do you understand? — with my vile contaminated body next to hers, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

The Son

the one who will not act

37 speeches · 778 words across the production

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing. His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. Make it count.

COLD-READ LINE

“I am an 'unrealised' character, dramatically speaking; and I feel ill at ease in their company.”

Act Three — the refuser defines himself

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

The Son

SIDE 1 *Act Three — the mirror speech*

The Son. Yes, but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror which not only freezes us with the image of ourselves, but throws our likeness back at us with a horrible grimace?

SIDE 2 *Act Two — first arrival of the family*

The Son. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

SIDE 3 *Act Three — refusing the production*

The Son. [*half to himself, meaning the Mother to hear*]. And they want to put it on the stage! If there was at least a reason for it! He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us in every circumstance of life couldn't find his own explanation of it! [*Pauses.*] He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live and are man and wife for themselves, quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

The Manager

the director on a deadline

199 speeches · 3,791 words across the production

Whatever an exhausted, competent theatre director at the end of a difficult week looks like — the schedule burning, faintly contemptuous of the playwright he has been forced to stage, faintly proud of his company. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway. He is wrong in tone almost constantly, and right in instinct almost as often. Do not play him as a fool. Give him compassion. He is everyone in the audience who has ever been forced to make sense of someone else's grief on a deadline.

COLD-READ LINE

“I've lost a whole day over these people.”

Act Three — the curtain line

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

The Manager

SIDE 1 *Act One — the anti-Pirandello rant*

The Manager. *[jumping up in a rage].* Ridiculous? Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies — Paris seems to be keeping them all for itself — and we are reduced to putting on Pirandello, whom nobody understands, including (I am beginning to suspect) Pirandello himself, who plays the fool with all of us and pockets the royalties from the comfort of the grave? *[The Actors grin. The Manager goes to Leading Man and shouts.]* Yes sir, you put on the cook's cap and beat eggs. Do you suppose that with all this egg-beating business you are on an ordinary stage? Get that out of your head. You represent the shell of the eggs you are beating! *[Laughter and comments among the Actors.]* Silence! and listen to my explanations, please! *[To Leading Man.]* "The empty form of reason without the fullness of instinct, which is blind." — You stand for reason, your wife is instinct. It's a mixing up of the parts, according to which you who act your own part become the puppet of yourself. Do you understand?

SIDE 2 *Act Three — directing the climax*

The Manager. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[Picks up the chair-and-coat and places it behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

Player 1

the man with all the hats

44 speeches · 638 words across the production

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. The Leading Man's vanity is his spine in Act One: the cook's-cap argument with the Manager, the strut, the offence at being asked to wear a chef's hat in a serious play. The Door-keeper is small, apologetic, and lets the wrong six people in. The Machinist is the one who drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two. Every transition between roles must be visible to the audience — the hat-toss, the change of bearing, the lift of the chin. Lean into the Leading Man early. The contrast with everything else will land harder later.

COLD-READ LINE

“Excuse me — must I really wear a cook's cap? I trained at the Conservatoire for this.”

Act One — the Leading Man's vanity

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

Player 1

SIDE 1 *Act One — at the family's arrival*

Player 1 (as Leading Man). *[to the Company]*. What a spectacle. What an absolute treat. I shall write to my agent — if I still have one in this country.

SIDE 2 *Act One — outrage*

Player 1 (as Leading Man). It's absolutely unheard of. If the stage has come to this — well, I'm going back to television. To Geneva, even, if I must. At least on television the audience cannot walk onto the set.

SIDE 3 *Act One — as Door-keeper*

Player 1 (as Door-keeper). I only let them in. Don't blame me. They had the look of money. I thought they were patrons. From Vevey, possibly. They had that — *vous voyez* — that air about them.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

Player 2

the diva and the props

41 speeches · 486 words across the production

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. The Leading Lady is offended at being made to play the Step-Daughter, and offended again when the Step-Daughter laughs at her attempt. The Property Man is the working theatre itself — the table, the folding screen, the pegs, the patience the director has personally exhausted. Two opposite registers in the same body: the vanity that costs nothing, and the labour that costs everything. Let the audience see her flip between them in the same scene. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory.

COLD-READ LINE

“A game! For heaven's sake — we are not children. We are serious actors.”

Act Two — the Leading Lady refusing 'the game'

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

Player 2

SIDE 1 *Act Two — as Leading Lady*

Player 2 (as Leading Lady). *[interrupting indignantly]*. A game! For heaven's sake — we are not children. We are serious actors. With training — some of us from the Conservatoire. With agents. With opinions on Stanislavski.

SIDE 2 *Act Two — wounded vanity*

Player 2 (as Leading Lady). *[indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go. And I take half this audience with me. They come for me. Most of them are friends of mine.

SIDE 3 *Act Two — during the shop scene*

Player 2 (as Leading Lady). One can't hear a word. I would have preferred surtitles.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

Player 3

the youngest, and Madame Pace

29 speeches · 555 words across the production

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, Madame Pace, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. The Juvenile Lead is eager and slightly ridiculous. The Prompter is in his box, sometimes a court stenographer, sometimes complaining about the draught. Then comes the production's most theatrically demanding moment: Madame Pace, an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne, an apparition summoned by the very arrangement of the stage — hats on pegs, a shop window with the sign *robes et manteaux*, a folding screen. Player 3 enters her costume the way an apparition enters a body — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. She is a businesswoman of shame: elegant, practical, smiling, and morally rotten. She does not shout — her danger comes from being calm. Play the comedy of her dialect at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit. The audience laughs when she enters, and is disgusted with itself for having laughed by the time she leaves — that double sensation is the point of her. **Do not let her become an accent joke.** The accent is the entrance. The bookkeeping is the body of her.

COLD-READ LINE

“This is rank madness. Beautiful rank madness — but madness.”

Act One — the Juvenile Lead

Audition sides for this role follow on the next page.

AUDITION SIDES

Player 3

SIDE 1 *Act One — as Juvenile Lead*

Player 3 (as Juvenile Lead). This is rank madness. Beautiful rank madness — but madness.

SIDE 2 *Act One — disbelief*

Player 3 (as Juvenile Lead). And he takes them seriously! He has notes. There is — I can see from here — a notebook.

Prepare one or more of the sides above. Callbacks may include cold reads from other scenes.

SILENT PRESENCES — NOT CAST

The Boy and the Child — the two youngest of the Six — are not played by performers in this production. The Boy is a black coat and a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a leather satchel at the chair leg. The Child is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, carried by the Step-Daughter and the Mother. They appear briefly in three short projections and otherwise live in the chair and the bundle.